AI IN GOVERNMENT AND PUBLIC SERVICES - VOLUME 7

The Emergency Services and Public Safety Playbook

Minutes saved before anyone arrives - with AI that listens, locates, summarises and drafts, and call-takers, dispatchers and commanders who decide.



Gates E0-E5 | 8 Templates | 20 Golden Rules

The worked example continues: **Northbridge City and County**, a fictional composite government of 480,000 residents whose joint Emergency Communications Centre answers 390,000 emergency and urgent calls a year for police, fire and ambulance partners - 24 call-takers and dispatchers on a peak shift, one river, two hospitals, a stadium and a motorway junction. Every figure attached to Northbridge is illustrative. Adapt thresholds to your own law, protocols and risk appetite.

Executive / Service / Accountability lenses on every major section, so a chief officer, a caller in the worst minute of their year and a coroner, auditor or inquiry can read the same page and each find their decision.

START HERE

In this service, minutes are the currency

Every other volume in this series deals in days, weeks and budgets. This one deals in minutes - sometimes seconds. A call answered faster, a location pinned tighter, a unit sent sooner: those are the gains. But emergency response is also where a wrong automated decision does the fastest, least reversible harm of any service in this series. The design problem is therefore sharp: take every second AI can safely give back, and give nothing of judgement away.

How to use this playbook

- **Chiefs and executives** read pages 4-7 for the lifecycle, the value map and the stop list, then pages 23-27 for measurement, economics and the gates.
- **Control room leaders** work pages 8-15 in order - that is the live chain from call to command.
- **Everyone** reads page 6, the stop list, before any procurement conversation. If a supplier demo crosses it, the meeting is over.

The one line: AI listens, locates, summarises and drafts. Call-takers, dispatchers and commanders decide - who goes, how fast, and what happens on scene.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund seconds, not dashboards. The business case is answer time, location accuracy and dispatch quality.

SERVICE LENS

The caller never meets the AI. They meet a calmer human who already has the address, the history and the right questions.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every AI suggestion in a live incident must be reconstructable afterwards: what it saw, what it proposed, what the human did.

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Gates E0-E5 are the control spine: no use case advances a gate without the evidence page 27 names. Templates are fill-in working documents, not paperwork for its own sake.

THE WORK

The response lifecycle, end to end

An emergency is a chain, and the chain is only as strong as its slowest link. Northbridge mapped its own chain before buying anything and found the uncomfortable truth most centres find: crews were fast, and the minutes were being lost before dispatch - in ringing, in address confusion, in re-asked questions.

Stage	What happens	Where minutes hide	Human decision
Call	Caller reaches the centre by phone, text, app or alarm	Ring and queue time; abandoned calls	Answer and stay on the line
Locate	Address, landmark and caller location established	Spelling, similar street names, rural and high-rise ambiguity	Confirm the location, out loud
Understand	Nature, severity and risk established by protocol questions	Distress, language, third-party callers, incomplete information	Grade the incident
Dispatch	Right unit, right route, right information sent	Unit choice, cross-border cover, missing hazard information	Commit the unit
Respond	Crews travel, arrive, act; centre supports en route	Traffic, access details, updates not relayed	Command on scene
Record and learn	Log, recordings and outcome reviewed; patterns acted on	Unreviewed near-misses; repeat addresses never flagged	Review, refer, improve

The AI opportunity sits mostly in stages two, three and six - locate, understand, record. The accountability sits in stages three, four and five, and it stays human.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Map your own chain first. Most centres discover their delay is not where the vendor pitch assumed.

SERVICE LENS

Each stage is a promise: answer fast, locate surely, grade fairly, send rightly.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Stage six is where accountability is built - or lost. Fund review time like response time.

VALUE MAP

Where AI pays - and where it does not

Use case	Value	Risk if careless	Gate to start
Live transcription and call summary	Call-taker types less, listens more; handover is instant	Errors quoted as fact in the log	E1
Location enrichment (device location, gazetteer, landmarks)	Cuts the single biggest source of delay	False precision - a pin treated as certainty	E1
Protocol prompt support	Consistent key questions, none skipped under pressure	Prompt becomes autopilot; caller treated as form	E2
Real-time language translation	Immediate help in the caller's language	Mistranslation of symptoms, threats or addresses	E2
Unit recommendation	Nearest capable unit with full picture, proposed fast	Automation bias; cover stripped from quiet areas	E3
Duplicate and linked-incident detection	Ten calls about one fire become one incident, ten witnesses	Real second incident merged away	E2
Public alert drafting	Warnings out in minutes, in plain language, signed by an officer	Unreviewed warning causes panic or complacency	E2
Recording redaction for disclosure	Hours of manual redaction become reviewable drafts	A voice or face missed; a victim exposed	E3

Notice the pattern: AI pays where the work is **listening, finding, linking and drafting**. It does not pay - it endangers - where the work is judging credibility, grading risk alone, or committing resources irreversibly.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sequence by value divided by irreversibility. Transcription first, dispatch support last.

SERVICE LENS

Callers gain time and clarity, never a machine between them and help.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Start every use case in shadow mode: AI proposes, humans act as before, differences are studied.

NON-NEGOTIABLES

The stop list: decisions AI never makes

This list is policy, not preference. It is signed by the chief officers, shown to suppliers before demos, and printed in the control room. A use case that needs an exception does not get one quietly - it goes to the gold commander group and, if approved, is recorded as a named, dated exception with an owner.

Never automated	Why	What AI may do instead
Committing or withholding a dispatch	Irreversible, time-critical, and answerable in inquiries	Recommend, with reasons shown; dispatcher commits
Downgrading or closing an incident	A closed call that was real is the worst outcome in the service	Flag possible duplicates; a human closes
Identifying a suspect or matching a face	Error plus bias at liberty stakes; a law-enforcement question, not a control-room one	Nothing. Out of scope for this centre
Use-of-force or tactical recommendations	Command judgement under law, never a model's	Provide information only, on request, logged
Denying or delaying help on a vulnerability or safeguarding flag	Flags exist to add care, never to ration it	Surface the flag; the human adds the response
Issuing a public warning without a named officer's approval	The public acts on these words; someone must own them	Draft in seconds; officer edits and releases
Scoring a caller's credibility or truthfulness	Distress sounds like evasion to a model; the consequences are lethal	Transcribe faithfully, without commentary

> **The test for anything new:** if this went wrong at 3 a.m. on the worst night of the year, who stands in the inquiry and explains it? If the honest answer is 'the system', it belongs on this list.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Hold the list publicly. It is the strongest trust asset the centre owns.

SERVICE LENS

Nothing on this list makes a caller's experience worse; it guarantees a human owns the moment.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The list is reviewed after every serious incident and every supplier upgrade - upgrades move systems toward the line.

PRINCIPLES

Principles for AI at emergency tempo

1. **Seconds are saved for humans to spend.** Every automation is judged by what the call-taker does with the time it returns - listen, reassure, question - not by headcount.
2. **The human hears the caller; the AI hears the room.** Transcription, timers, checklists and lookups run in the background. The person stays in the foreground.
3. **Confidence is displayed, never hidden.** A location pin shows its radius. A transcript marks uncertain words. A recommendation shows its reasons.
4. **Override is one action, always.** Any AI output can be dismissed instantly, without a reason code, mid-call. Friction on override is a safety defect.
5. **Degrade gracefully, rehearse the degradation.** When AI fails, the room falls back to the pre-AI way of working - practised, not improvised (page 25).
6. **The log is the truth.** AI contributions are marked as AI contributions in the incident record, forever. No silent edits, no retroactive tidying.
7. **Equity at tempo.** Accents, languages, speech impairments and distressed speech are the normal case, tested as such - not edge cases discovered in production.
8. **Calm is a design requirement.** Interfaces that flash, alarm and compete for attention in a surge are rejected, however clever.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Principles are procurement criteria. Score bids against these eight, in writing.

SERVICE LENS

Callers feel principles 2, 3 and 7 directly. Test with real call recordings and community panels.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

An auditor should be able to trace any incident decision to a principle and a named human.

LIVE CHAIN 1 OF 6

Call intake: the first sixty seconds

The first minute decides the call. The caller is often frightened, injured, hiding, or calling for someone else. The call-taker's craft - voice, pace, control - is the service. AI earns its place here only by removing everything that competes with that craft.

What runs from the first ring

- **Live transcription** in the call-taker's view, uncertain words visibly marked, so notes stop competing with listening.
- **Instant location bundle** - device location with accuracy radius, registered address, nearby landmarks - presented as claims to confirm, not facts to assume.
- **Address and hazard lookups** resolved silently in the background: access codes held legitimately, known hazards, previous incidents at the address shown as context, never as prejudice.
- **A running incident skeleton** - who, where, what - filling itself from the conversation for the call-taker to correct, so the dispatch record starts at second ten, not minute two.

> **Northbridge, illustrative:** transcription plus the location bundle cut average time-to-dispatch-ready from 94 to 61 seconds on piloted queues - and call-takers reported the larger gain was calmer callers, because no one was asked to spell a street name three times.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Intake is the cheapest place to buy minutes: no vehicles, no stations, just attention returned.

SERVICE LENS

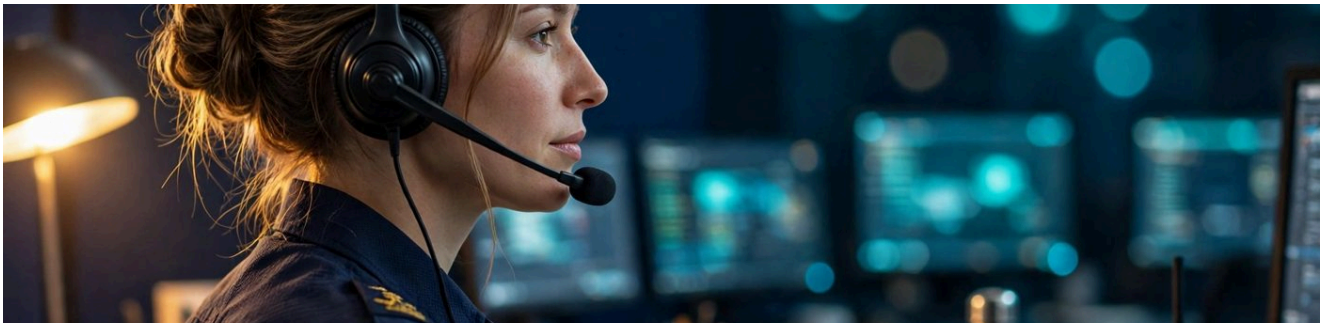
The caller hears a human fully present. That is the entire design goal.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Review a sample of calls weekly: did the bundle help, mislead, or get ignored? All three answers are data.

LIVE CHAIN 2 OF 6

Triage support, never triage denial



A Northbridge call-taker at work: the AI transcribes and prompts in the background, the human listens in the foreground

Structured triage protocols save lives because they ask the question a stressed human might skip. AI support makes the protocol easier to follow under pressure: the next key question surfaced, answers captured from speech, elapsed-time and red-flag prompts shown quietly. The grading decision - category, priority, response - is made by the call-taker or clinician, and the system records who graded, on what answers.

- **Prompts advise, they do not gate.** A call-taker can always move faster than the protocol when the caller's words demand it.
- **Red flags escalate automatically to a human** - breathing difficulty, weapons, a child alone - but nothing de-escalates automatically.
- **Under-triage is the audited error.** Over-triage costs resources; under-triage costs people. Review samples weight the errors accordingly, and any AI change is tested for its under-triage effect first.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund triage support only with its audit: sampled re-grading by senior clinicians and call-takers, published internally.

SERVICE LENS

A caller in extremis never hears a protocol being wrestled with. The support is silent when it works.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every grade must be explainable from the recorded answers - not from a model score.

LIVE CHAIN 3 OF 6

Language, accessibility and silent callers

An emergency service that only works fluently in one language, in a clear voice, on a good line, is a service for the easiest emergencies. Northbridge's call mix includes 40-plus languages in a year, text-based contact from deaf callers, silent calls that are sometimes nothing and sometimes a person who cannot speak safely.

- **Real-time translation, both ways,** with the original audio and words preserved and shown beside the translation. Safety-critical terms - symptoms, weapons, fire locations - are rendered by approved phrase sets where they exist, and uncertainty is flagged, never smoothed over.
- **Text and relay parity.** Text, video-relay and app contacts enter the same queue discipline and the same triage, with transcription native rather than bolted on.
- **Silent-call handling stays human-led.** AI may detect sounds, keywords or patterns in the background audio and surface them to the call-taker. It never classifies a silent call as a hoax and never ends one.
- **Speech difference is tested, not tolerated.** Transcription accuracy is measured separately for accented, impaired, elderly and child speech, and published by cohort - a single average accuracy figure is treated as a concealment.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Equity here is not a programme, it is response time by cohort. Measure it that way.

SERVICE LENS

The caller using their second language in a crisis gets the same calm and the same speed of help.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Cohort-level accuracy reporting is a contract term, with remedies, not a dashboard favour.

LIVE CHAIN 4 OF 6

Location and mapping: the highest-value fix

Ask any crew where minutes die and they will say the same thing: the last 400 metres. A correct street is not a location - the right tower entrance, the flat above the shop, the gate on the unlit lane is. Location work is unglamorous and it outperforms every other AI investment in this volume.

Location problem	AI-assisted fix	Human check
Device pin inaccurate or stale	Fuse device, network and registered address into one claim with a radius	Call-taker confirms against what the caller can see
Similar street names across districts	Disambiguation prompted by district, landmark and postcode fragments	Address read back in full before dispatch
High-rise and campus complexity	Floor, stairwell, entrance and lift data from building records surfaced with the address	Caller or concierge confirms entry point
Rural and off-road incidents	Trailheads, water access points, grid references and rendezvous points proposed	Crew confirms rendezvous by radio
Moving callers	Location refreshed during the call, movement shown as a track with timestamps	Dispatcher narrates updates to the crew

Rule of the pin: a location is a claim with an accuracy attached. The interface that shows a pin without its radius is lying by design, and is rejected at procurement.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund the gazetteer and building data before the clever models. Data quality is the location product.

SERVICE LENS

Callers are guided to help locate themselves - windows, landmarks, what they can hear.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Location claims and their sources are logged, so a wrong pin can be learned from, not just regretted.

LIVE CHAIN 5 OF 6

Dispatch decision support

Dispatch is choreography under scarcity: the right unit now, cover kept for the next call, crews told what they are walking into. AI support assembles the dispatcher's picture - incident summary drafted from the call, hazards and access attached, unit options ranked with reasons, cover impact shown - and the dispatcher commits, amends or ignores it in seconds.

- **Recommendations show their working:** distance, capability, current tasking, cover consequence. A bare ranking is not accepted.
- **The incident brief travels with the unit:** what is known, what is uncertain, what the caller said in their own words where it matters - flagged as transcript, not paraphrased into false certainty.
- **Updates flow back:** en-route information, second callers and scene reports are summarised into the same brief, versioned, so crews are never working from a stale picture.
- **Pre-alerts are human-sent.** AI may prepare a crew pre-alert on a high-grade call; a person sends it.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Dispatch support is where saved call minutes convert into saved response minutes. Measure the conversion.

SERVICE LENS

Crews receive honest uncertainty. 'Caller reports smoke, unconfirmed' beats a confident error.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Log acceptance and override rates by dispatcher and hour. Overrides are intelligence, not disobedience.

LIVE CHAIN 6 OF 6

Unit recommendation and routing

"Nearest" is a beginner's answer. The right unit is the nearest *capable* unit whose commitment does not strip cover from a higher-risk area, routed on live conditions, with a crew whose skills match the incident as graded. Recommendation engines earn trust by being right about the second and third parts, and by saying so plainly.

Factor	In the recommendation	Never in the recommendation
Capability	Skills, equipment, crew size matched to the graded incident	Assumptions about a crew from past incidents at an address
Cover	Effect on remaining cover by area and hour, shown numerically	Quietly stripping a district because its callers complain less
Route	Live traffic, closures, access constraints, rendezvous points	Routes through areas flagged only by historic enforcement data
Workload	Shift position, recent traumatic incidents, rest status where recorded	Individual performance scoring of named crew members
Cross-border	Mutual-aid units proposed with the agreement terms attached	Committing a partner agency's unit without its dispatcher's consent

Northbridge runs recommendation in shadow for a full quarter before any dispatcher sees it live, then live for senior dispatchers first. The acceptance target is deliberately not 100 percent: a recommendation nobody ever overrides is either perfect or feared, and it is not perfect.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Judge the engine on outcomes - response time and cover kept - not acceptance rate.

SERVICE LENS

Crews see why they were sent. 'Nearest capable, bridge closure avoided' builds trust in one line.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Mutual-aid recommendations respect sovereignty: propose across the border, commit only with consent.

SURGE

Surge: when the room fills in ten minutes

Storms, major incidents and New Year's midnight share a shape: call volume multiplies faster than staffing can. Surge is where AI helps most visibly and fails most dangerously, because every shortcut is taken exactly when scrutiny is thinnest.

- **Duplicate detection becomes the front line:** fifty calls about one motorway collision are linked into one incident with fifty witnesses, and callers reporting the known incident are offered a fast confirmation path - staffed by humans, with the full triage one step away, never a dead end.
- **Non-emergency deflection is honest:** callers told truthfully that this line is overwhelmed, given the alternative channel and a callback commitment - not held in a silent queue by a soothing recording.
- **Overflow agreements activate:** partner centres take calls on shared protocols, with the same AI support and the same stop list, rehearsed twice a year, not negotiated mid-storm.
- **Nothing new switches on during a surge.** Models, prompts and thresholds are frozen for the duration. The middle of a storm is not a deployment window.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Surge capacity is bought in peacetime: overflow agreements, linked-incident tooling, rehearsed fallbacks.

SERVICE LENS

The public hears honesty about waits and alternatives. A truthful message preserves trust for the next emergency.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

After-action review of every surge is published internally within ten working days, AI performance included.

Command support in major incidents



Northbridge commanders around a shared 3D incident picture: the AI maintains the picture, commanders make the decisions

In a major incident the scarcest resource is a shared, current picture: what has happened, what is deployed, what has been decided, what is still unknown. AI support maintains that picture - incident log drafted from radio and phone traffic, timeline assembled, resource state kept current, situation reports drafted for the commander's edit and signature.

- **The log is drafted, never authored.** Every entry attributable, every AI-drafted line confirmed by the loggist before it becomes the record an inquiry will read.
- **Decisions are recorded as decisions:** who decided, when, on what information. AI summaries must never blur a decision into the narrative.
- **Forecasts are labelled as forecasts:** casualty estimates, fire spread, flood extent - shown with their basis and their uncertainty, and never quoted onward without both.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Command support succeeds if the commander thinks less about information and more about decisions.

SERVICE LENS

Public and partner agencies receive one picture, owned and signed by command.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The incident log standard is inquiry-grade from minute one, not reconstructed afterwards.

DIFFERENCES

Police, fire and ambulance are not the same problem

Dimension	Police	Fire and rescue	Ambulance
Call shape	Often adversarial, third-party or covert risk	Usually unambiguous event, location critical	Clinical detail decisive; caller often not the patient
AI that helps	Call summarisation, linked reports, language support	Location precision, building and hazmat data, spread forecasts labelled as forecasts	Protocol prompt support, hospital-capacity picture, clinician callback queues
Distinctive danger	Credibility or risk scoring of callers and areas	Over-confident prediction of fire behaviour	Under-triage; automated clinical advice
Hard line	No suspect identification, no enforcement selection from call data	No automated evacuation or entry decisions	No automated refusal, downgrade or self-help-only outcome

A shared platform with shared plumbing - transcription, location, logging - is sound economics. Shared decision logic across the three services is not. Each service keeps its own protocols, its own gates evidence, and its own chief officer's signature on its stop list.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Buy shared plumbing, govern decisions separately. The savings are real and so is the distinction.

SERVICE LENS

Patients, witnesses and residents experience three different services; design reviews should too.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Each service's serious-incident reviews stay separate, with a joint review only where the incident was joint.

VULNERABILITY

Vulnerability, safeguarding and repeat callers

Control rooms hear from the same addresses and the same voices, often for years: the resident with dementia who calls nightly, the household where calls keep ending abruptly, the caller whose "minor" reports form a pattern no single call reveals. Pattern detection is one of AI's genuine gifts here - and one of its easiest abuses.

- **Patterns are surfaced to people who can help:** repeat-caller and repeat-address summaries go to a named human reviewer - a safeguarding lead, a neighbourhood team, a clinician - who decides whether a welfare referral, a care-plan contact or no action is right.
- **A flag adds care, never subtracts response.** A frequent-caller flag changes who reviews the call pattern; it never changes whether tonight's call is answered, graded and responded to on its own facts.
- **Callers are told, in plain terms,** when a care referral is made about them where the law allows, with a route to challenge the record.
- **Cohort audits run quarterly:** are flags falling disproportionately on particular communities, ages or conditions? A pattern tool trained on historic response patterns will inherit them unless audited against outcomes.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund the human pathway first - safeguarding leads and partner capacity - then the detection that feeds it.

SERVICE LENS

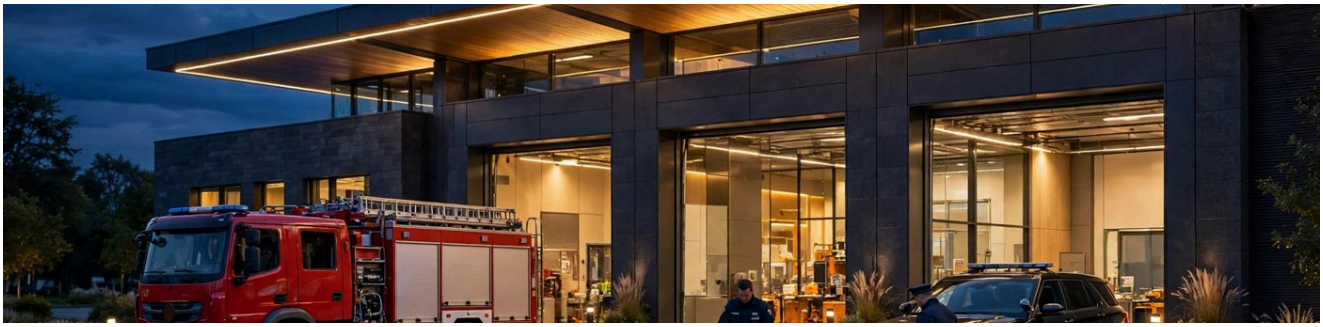
For the repeat caller, success feels like a person who knows their situation, not a shorter call.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every flag has an owner, an expiry and a challenge route. Orphan flags are deleted, not kept.

PUBLIC INFORMATION 1 OF 2

Public alerts and warnings people act on



Northbridge crews preparing at dusk: public warnings work when they tell people exactly what to do, by when, and where

A warning is an intervention: evacuate this street, avoid that water, expect this road closed until morning. AI drafting collapses the time from decision to publication from forty minutes to four - draft in the approved formats, in plain language, in the area's main languages, geotargeted from the incident footprint - and a named officer reviews, edits and releases. The officer's name and the time are on the warning.

- **Every warning answers four questions:** what is happening, who is affected, what to do, and when the next update comes.
- **Channels match the audience:** cell broadcast, local radio, social channels, community networks - drafted once, adapted per channel, never copy-pasted blindly.
- **The all-clear is a warning too,** drafted and signed with the same discipline, so people are not left living under a lifted risk.
- **Warning performance is measured by behaviour** - did the street empty, did calls fall - not by impressions.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Speed of warning is a life-safety metric. Report it beside response times.

SERVICE LENS

Residents act on specific, local, signed instructions. Vague reassurance is measured and found wanting.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Warning drafts, edits and release times are public-record material. Keep them that way.

PUBLIC INFORMATION 2 OF 2

Misinformation and the public information duty

During a major incident, the information vacuum fills within minutes - with old footage, wrong locations and confident invention. The centre's duty is not to police the internet; it is to be the fastest reliable source in its own incident, and to correct the specific falsehoods that change behaviour or endanger crews.

- **Monitoring is scoped to the incident:** AI tools scan public channels for the incident's places, claims and imagery, and surface rising falsehoods to the communications officer. Standing surveillance of the public is out of scope and out of policy.
- **Corrections are specific and sourced:** "The bridge is open; the closure is at Mill Road" with a time and a link to the live update page - never a general plea to trust official sources.
- **Rumour logs are kept:** what circulated, what was corrected, what effect it had on calls and behaviour. They feed the after-action review.
- **Pre-bunking for predictable risks:** flood, heat and storm seasons get prepared explainers and warning templates approved in advance, so the first message of the real event is fast because it is half-written honestly, in peacetime.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund a two-person public information cell in major incidents. It outperforms any tool purchase.

SERVICE LENS

The public gets corrections at the speed of the rumour, in the channel the rumour used.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Incident-scoped monitoring only, with the scope, tools and retention published. Mission creep is the audited risk.

RECORDS

Records, redaction and evidence discipline

Emergency recordings are evidence, disclosure material and, for the people on them, often the worst minutes of their lives. AI redaction and summarisation make disclosure feasible at volume; they also create a new way to fail a victim, by missing the one detail that should never have left the building.

- **Redaction is drafted by AI and verified by a person,** with verification sampling rates set by the sensitivity of the material - and 100 percent verification for anything involving children, victims of sexual offences, or protected identities under law.
- **Summaries are labelled and linked:** every AI summary carries a link to the underlying recording and transcript, and is marked as a summary wherever it travels. A summary quoted in court without its source is a process failure, owned by the process.
- **Retention follows the schedule, not the storage bill:** recordings, transcripts, AI drafts and logs each have retention rules set by law and inquiry practice. Cheap storage is not an argument for keeping everything forever.
- **Access is logged at person level.** Who listened, who exported, who shared - reviewable, and reviewed.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Disclosure speed is a justice issue: late evidence changes outcomes. Fund redaction review, not just redaction software.

SERVICE LENS

Requesters and victims get complete, careful material - speed never traded against a missed redaction.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The audit trail of access is as important as the redaction itself. Sample it monthly.

THE DESK

The call-taker and dispatcher desk

One screen philosophy governs the desk: **the call first, the incident second, the system third**. What the practitioner sees, in priority order: the caller and the conversation; the incident picture the AI maintains; controls. Everything else - analytics, targets, management information - lives somewhere the live desk is not.

Desk element	Standard
Transcription panel	Live, uncertainty marked, one-click correction that feeds model improvement
Location claim	Pin plus radius, sources listed, confirm and correct both one action
Recommendation card	Proposal, reasons, cover effect, accept / amend / dismiss - dismiss needs no reason
Timer and protocol strip	Elapsed times and next key questions, quiet colours, no flashing
AI status indicator	Always visible: working, degraded, off. No silent failure states
Handover button	One action sends the maintained incident skeleton to the receiving human or agency

Desk changes are tested with night-shift staff on recorded surge calls before procurement, not demonstrated by vendors on quiet Tuesday scenarios.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Desk design is response-time design. Fund practitioner testing as a deliverable, not a favour.

SERVICE LENS

Staff feel respected or monitored by this screen. Co-design decides which.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Override and correction rates are desk-quality metrics: high friction shows up there first.

WORKFORCE

Wellbeing: the humans inside the tempo

Call-takers absorb trauma by ear, at volume, with seconds between calls. AI changes this exposure in both directions, and an honest programme measures both. Transcription removes the typing burden and the post-call paperwork pile - a real relief. Continuous AI monitoring of calls, if introduced carelessly, becomes continuous surveillance of the monitored - a real harm.

- **Post-incident decompression is protected:** after a call tagged traumatic - by the call-taker's one-touch tag, not an algorithm's judgement alone - the system routes the next calls elsewhere and the break is real.
- **AI call analysis for welfare is opt-in and aggregate:** identifying that night shifts after storms carry heavy loads is legitimate workforce planning. Scoring an individual's voice for stress or performance is a red line, crossed only - if ever - under explicit agreement with staff representatives.
- **Training uses simulation:** AI-voice simulated callers let trainees practise rare, hard calls - the silent caller, the child caller, the collapsing patient - without practising on the public.
- **Saved time is partly banked as recovery:** the programme board states in advance what share of efficiency gain becomes staffing relief and breaks, so the dividend is not silently all throughput.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Wellbeing is operational: rested call-takers answer better. The case writes itself.

SERVICE LENS

Staff who trust the tools use the overrides and corrections that keep the public safe.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Any people-analytics use of call AI requires staff-side agreement in writing, before deployment.

MEASUREMENT

Measurement: minutes, accuracy and harm

Measure	Definition that matters	Watch for
Answer time	Ring to human voice, median and 90th percentile, by hour	Averages hiding the storm hours
Time to located	Call start to confirmed location, by call type	Urban-rural and language gaps
Time to dispatch	Confirmed location and grade to unit committed	Gains at intake lost in dispatch queues
Location accuracy	Crews arriving within the claimed radius, sampled	Radius claims shrinking to look good
Under-triage rate	Independent re-grading of sampled calls, weighted as the serious error	Any AI release that moves it, in either direction, unexplained
Override rate and reasons	Dispatcher and call-taker overrides of AI outputs	Rates near zero (fear) or climbing (distrust)
Equity cuts	Every measure above, cut by language, area, age band and access channel	An improvement that is an average of a gain and a harm
Public warning time	Decision to published warning, per major incident	Draft speed celebrated while sign-off queues grow

Reporting rule: no measure is reported without its equity cut and its worst hour. A service for emergencies is judged on its worst hour by design.

EXECUTIVE LENS

These eight measures fit on one page, monthly, to the chief officers. Nothing else needs a dashboard.

SERVICE LENS

Callers experience the 90th percentile, not the median. Publish both.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

An unexplained improvement is investigated like an unexplained deterioration. Both mean the system changed.

ECONOMICS

Economics: what a saved minute is worth

Do not monetise lives with false precision, and do not refuse to count costs either. The honest economics of control-room AI are mostly mundane: overtime avoided at surge, dispatchers retained because the job became sustainable, disclosure deadlines met without agency staff, and - at the top of the ledger - response-time gains whose value the community sets politically, not actuarially.

Cost / benefit	How Northbridge counts it (illustrative)
Platform and licences	Per-seat and per-call pricing both modelled; per-call pricing penalises surge honesty and is capped contractually
Integration	Computer-aided dispatch, telephony, recording and mapping integration priced as a project, not discovered as one
Assurance labour	Re-grading panels, redaction verification and cohort audits budgeted as permanent posts
Training and simulation	Backfill for training hours included, or training silently does not happen
Benefit: intake minutes	Valued as capacity released at peak, where the constraint actually binds
Benefit: retention	Call-taker attrition cost per leaver tracked; even small reductions fund much of the programme
Benefit: disclosure compliance	Deadline performance and avoided legal cost, counted conservatively

The figure never claimed: a dollar value per life. Where faster response plausibly changes outcomes, the volume says so in words and lets elected members weigh it - the same discipline as Volume 5 applied to money that arrives under sirens.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Approve economics on capacity, retention and compliance. Treat outcome gains as the mission case, stated plainly.

SERVICE LENS

The public ledger shows costs the same way: no invented precision.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Audit the benefit claims annually against page 23 measures, and publish the reconciliation.

RESILIENCE

Failure, outage and the paper fallback

The control room's AI will fail: a model outage, a telephony fault, a bad update, a cyber incident (the attacker's view is the AI Security Series' territory; here the duty is continuity). The question this page answers is what the room does in the first sixty seconds of that failure - because a room that has rehearsed it barely notices, and a room that has not, improvises at the worst moment.

- **Failure is announced, not discovered:** the desk's AI status indicator (page 21) turns, an audible and logged alert fires, and the shift commander declares fallback mode on the record.
- **Fallback is the old craft, kept alive:** manual logging, memory of the gazetteer, protocol cards. Skills that fallback depends on are practised monthly in no-AI drills - automation that erodes the fallback skill is a debt with a due date.
- **Updates are frozen and staged:** no model or prompt changes reach the live room without a tested rollback and a quiet-period deployment window - never before a forecast storm, major event or holiday peak.
- **Recovery reconciles the record:** calls handled in fallback are back-filled and marked as fallback-handled; AI systems rejoining the room receive the record, not the other way round.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Continuity is a rehearsed performance, not a document. Drill it, time it, publish the drill results.

SERVICE LENS

Callers must never be able to tell, from the help they get, that the AI is down.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Fallback drills and update freezes are contractual obligations on suppliers, with service credits attached.

SUPPLIERS

Suppliers, interoperability and lock-in

Emergency systems are bought for a decade and regretted at leisure. The lock-in risks are specific: transcripts and incident data held in proprietary formats, models tuned on your calls that you cannot take with you, dispatch integrations that make the AI layer load-bearing for basic functions.

Contract term	Why it matters here
Full data export: audio, transcripts, logs, AI drafts and markings, in open formats	The record belongs to the public and the inquiry, not the vendor
AI-off operation guaranteed	Core telephony and dispatch must run indefinitely with the AI layer removed, tested annually
Model and prompt change notification	Silent changes at emergency tempo are unacceptable; changes are versioned, notified and reversible
Accuracy reporting by cohort, with remedies	Equity (page 10) enforced commercially, not aspirationally
No training on the centre's calls without explicit agreement	The public's worst minutes are not a data asset
Exit assistance and parallel running priced in advance	The next migration starts the day the contract is signed

EXECUTIVE LENS

Interoperability with partner agencies' systems outranks any single-vendor suite discount.

SERVICE LENS

Callers never see supplier terms, but they live with them. Buy for the inquiry in ten years.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The AI-off test is the accountability clause: run it, witness it, publish the result.

CONTROL SPINE

Gates E0-E5 and the 18-month roadmap

E0 - Baseline: lifecycle mapped, delays located, stop list signed by all three chief officers.

E1 - Listen: transcription, location bundle and incident skeleton live in shadow, then live on one queue; accuracy by cohort meets contract.

E2 - Support: protocol prompts, translation, duplicate linking and warning drafting live; under-triage audit running and stable.

E3 - Recommend: unit recommendation and redaction drafting live after a full shadow quarter; override culture measured and healthy.

E4 - Surge-proven: full stack exercised through a major incident or a full-scale exercise, overflow agreements activated in rehearsal.

E5 - Assured: independent assurance passed, AI-off test witnessed, equity and harm measures published; annual re-gate scheduled.

Roadmap, illustrative: months 0-3 baseline and gazetteer remediation; 4-6 E1 on the ambulance queue first, where protocol support is strongest; 7-9 E2 across services; 10-14 E3 with the shadow quarter; 15-18 surge exercise, E4 and independent assurance toward E5. Any serious incident resets the clock at the affected gate, by design.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Gates are stop points, not milestones. Each needs a named decision to pass, in a minute.

SERVICE LENS

The queue or service you start with is the one whose staff asked first, wherever possible.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Gate evidence is published to the oversight board in full, including the failures.

TEMPLATES 1-4

Fill-in templates: intake to recommendation

Template 1 - Use Case Safety Case

Use case / owner / service. Decision it supports, and the human who makes it. Stop-list check, signed. Failure mode at 3 a.m.: ____. Fallback: ____. Cohort risks: ____. Shadow-mode plan and duration: ____. Gate claimed: ____.

Template 2 - Call Review and Re-grading Form

Call ID / date / queue. Original grade and grader. Re-grade and reviewer. Differences and why. AI contribution: transcription errors? prompts followed or overridden? Location claim accurate? Learning action / owner / date.

Template 3 - Location Claim Record

Incident ID. Claims received: device (radius __), network (__), registered address, caller-described. Claim used for dispatch and confirmed by whom, when. Actual arrival point. Variance and cause. Gazetteer or building-data fix raised: Y/N.

Template 4 - Unit Recommendation Review

Incident ID / grade. Recommendation and reasons shown. Dispatcher action: accepted / amended / dismissed. Cover effect predicted vs actual. Outcome and response time. Pattern note for weekly review: ____.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Templates are completed in the flow of work or not at all. If a form needs a quiet hour, redesign the form.

SERVICE LENS

Callers never see templates; they feel their effects as consistency.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Template data feeds gates and audits. A template nobody aggregates is decoration.

TEMPLATES 5-8

Fill-in templates: warnings to incidents

Template 5 - Public Warning Release

Incident / warning number. What is happening. Who is affected (streets, areas). What to do, in order. Channels and languages. Drafted by (AI-assisted: Y/N). Edited and released by (named officer) / time. Next update due: ____. All-clear drafted: Y/N.

Template 6 - Surge Activation Checklist

Trigger and declared by / time. Duplicate-linking mode on. Overflow partners notified and accepting from: ____. Deflection message approved by: ____ (wording attached). Model and threshold freeze confirmed. Staffing call-ins issued. After-action review date set: ____.

Template 7 - Fallback and Outage Log

Failure detected / how. Fallback declared by / time. Services affected. Calls handled in fallback (count, IDs). Harm or delay incidents: ____. Recovery time. Reconciliation completed by: ____. Supplier credits claimed: Y/N.

Template 8 - Repeat Caller Pattern Review

Address / caller reference (no names in shared copies). Pattern summary and period. Reviewer (named human) and service. Options considered: welfare referral / care-plan contact / partner visit / no action, with reasons. Response to tonight's calls unchanged confirmed: Y/N. Flag expiry date and challenge route given: ____.

EXECUTIVE LENS

One page each, in practice. A template that grows past a page at emergency tempo stops being used.

SERVICE LENS

Templates 5 and 6 are signed documents. File them as public-record material from the start.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Template 8's last line is the safeguard: the pattern review never changes tonight's response.

ASSURANCE

Assurance checklist

- Stop list signed by all three chief officers, current version displayed in the control room and in supplier contracts.
- Every live use case has a Template 1 safety case, a named human decision-maker and a tested fallback.
- Transcription and translation accuracy reported by cohort - language, accent, age, speech impairment - within the last quarter.
- Under-triage re-grading panel active; results reviewed by the clinical and service leads monthly.
- Location claims display radius and source on every desk; variance log reviewed and gazetteer fixes progressing.
- Override and correction rates reviewed weekly; no unexplained trend in either direction.
- Public warnings in the last major incident: decision-to-publication times and signing officers on record.
- Redaction verification sampling at the rates page 20 sets; access logs sampled monthly.
- No-AI fallback drill completed within the last month; AI-off annual test scheduled and witnessed.
- Supplier change log current; no unnotified model or prompt change in the period.
- Wellbeing safeguards operating: decompression routing live, no individual voice scoring in use.
- Flag and pattern tools audited by cohort within the last quarter; expiries and challenge routes functioning.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Assurance is a standing agenda, twelve lines, monthly - not an annual inspection performance.

SERVICE LENS

Any line that cannot be checked today is a finding, not a footnote.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish the checklist result to the oversight board with the exceptions named.

GOLDEN RULES

Golden rules 1-10

1. **AI listens, locates, summarises and drafts. Humans decide.** If a proposal crosses that line, it goes on the stop list, not in the roadmap.
2. **Save seconds for humans to spend** - on listening, reassurance and judgement, not on headcount arithmetic.
3. **A location is a claim with a radius.** Never show a pin without its accuracy, never dispatch on an unconfirmed claim when confirmation takes ten seconds.
4. **Prompts advise; nothing de-escalates automatically.** Escalation may be automatic. Downgrading, closing and refusing are human acts.
5. **Under-triage is the error that matters.** Test every change for it first, and weight every audit by it.
6. **Override is one action and needs no excuse.** Friction on override is a safety defect, and override data is intelligence.
7. **Accuracy is reported by cohort or it is not reported.** Averages conceal exactly the callers the service exists for.
8. **A flag adds care, never subtracts response.** Tonight's call is answered on tonight's facts, whatever the pattern says.
9. **Warnings are signed.** A named officer, a time, four questions answered - what, who, what to do, when the next update comes.
10. **The log is the truth, marked as made.** AI-drafted lines are labelled, decisions are recorded as decisions, and nothing is tidied after the fact.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Rules 1, 4 and 8 belong in induction training in week one, before system training.

SERVICE LENS

Callers benefit from rules they will never read. That is the point of them.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

An inquiry will judge the centre against its own rules. Write rules you can be judged by.

GOLDEN RULES

Golden rules 11-20 - and what comes next

11. **Degrade gracefully, and rehearse the degradation.** The fallback is a practised craft, drilled monthly, not an improvised apology.
12. **Nothing new switches on during a surge.** Storms are not deployment windows.
13. **Buy shared plumbing, govern decisions separately.** Police, fire and ambulance share transcription - never triage logic.
14. **Measure the worst hour and the equity cut,** or do not report the measure at all.
15. **Saved time is partly banked as recovery.** Decide the share in advance, in writing, with staff at the table.
16. **The public's worst minutes are not a data asset.** No training on the centre's calls without explicit, published agreement.
17. **Core dispatch runs with the AI off,** indefinitely, tested annually, witnessed. If it cannot, the AI layer has become a single point of failure with a sales team.
18. **Correct rumours at the speed of the rumour,** specific and sourced, in the channel the rumour used.
19. **Fund the human pathway before the detection** - safeguarding leads before pattern tools, redaction reviewers before redaction software.
20. **When in doubt at 3 a.m., send help and argue later.** The benefit of the doubt belongs to the caller. It always has.

The series so far

Volume 1: Strategy (S0-S5). Volume 2: Citizen Services and Digital Front Doors (C0-C5). Volume 3: Benefits, Licensing and Casework (B0-B5). Volume 4: Permitting, Planning and Land Use (P0-P5). Volume 5: Tax, Revenue and Compliance (T0-T5). Volume 6: Procurement and Supplier AI. Volume 7: Emergency Services and Public Safety (E0-E5). Next: Data, Records and Interoperability, then the Capstone.

Northbridge City and County is fictional. Every figure in this volume is illustrative; adapt thresholds, protocols and targets to your own law, services and risk appetite.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Twenty rules, one test: could the night shift act on this, half-asleep, mid-storm? If not, redraft until they could.

SERVICE LENS

The series continues to the Capstone, where Northbridge's whole AI estate is assured end to end.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Golden rules are published. A public promise is the strongest governance tool in this volume.